

BACK IN POWER
Hemant Soren speaks at a meeting of allies in Ranchi on July 3

ANI

JHARKHAND

SOREN QUEERS PITCH FOR BJP

By Amitabh Srivastava

On July 3, less than a week after walking out of Ranchi's Birsa Munda Central Jail, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) executive president Hemant Soren staked claim to form the government in Jharkhand for the third time. This was after fellow party leader Champai Soren resigned as chief minister, barely 152 days after he had ascended to the post. Earlier in the day, MLAs of the state's ruling alliance (which includes the JMM, Congress and the Rashtriya Janata Dal) had elected Hemant as their leader. With just months to go before the state election scheduled for later this year, Hemant's release from custody in a land scam and money-laundering case, and subsequent return to power, has come as a shot in the arm for the JMM. But it has complicated the narrative for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which had been projecting the arrest as a fallout of Hemant's corruption—an allegation the JMM and its allies have denied. On its part, the JMM has accused the BJP-led government at the Centre of targeting Opposition parties and being anti-tribal—as a Santhal and a CM who was targeted, Hemant offers himself as an exemplar of both.

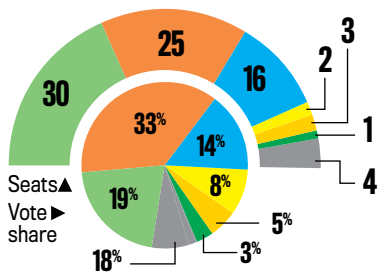
The JMM leader had been incarcerated since January 31 (though he was allowed to attend his uncle's funeral in May), after being arrested by the Enforcement Directorate, which registered a case against him under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

THE TRIBAL FACTOR

BJP's poor show in the 28 ST-reserved seats helped JMM and its allies clinch the 2019 polls

Assembly Election **2019**

Total seats **81**



Vote share figures have been rounded off

Champai was sworn in as CM following Hemant's resignation from the post ahead of his arrest. On June 28, after nearly five months in custody, Hemant was released on bail by the Jharkhand High Court, which observed that there was "reason to believe" he was "not guilty of the offence as alleged". Much has happened in Jharkhand during Hemant's time in custody. While the